

Linguistic Indifference V3

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1 Introduction

The foundational skill of analyzing an language choice, categorized within the pedagogical frameworks of close reading, is almost ubiquitously taught in American K-12. Within the K-12 continuum, this skill is explicitly codified as a developmental milestone in the Common Core State Standards, yet its status within the higher education landscape is characterized by a complex paradox (CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.R.L.6.4, CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.R.L.11-12.4). While undergraduate learning outcomes across most institutions continue to mandate complex lexical analysis, past research indicates a significant "corrosion" in this core proficiency among incoming students (Harris). This tension between institutional expectations and student readiness is aggravated by mounting corporate and STEM-driven labor needs, financial austerity schemes, and prevailing technological shifts (Noonan; Gramling and Malakaj 1). However, it has also catalyzed a reevaluation of how textual analysis is taught, especially within interdisciplinary and digital frameworks.

One such reevaluation centered on language-and-culture studies is the Pipestone Group's *Linguaphobia, Linguistic Indifference, and the Monolingual University Project* (LLIMU), an ongoing research initiative operating in the University of British Columbia that seeks to understand Anglocentric monolingualism and the multilingual decline within North American institutions. David Gramling and Ervin Malakaj, founders of the project, argue that the culmination of efficiency over complex intellectual work, the devaluation of multilingual knowledge as being creative rather than credible or scientific, and the push for automated translation over slow human translingual work have reduced the need of language learning as a meaningful component of the future university. In the pursuit for monolingual dominance, they also suggest that linguistic indifference (LI) - a dismissal or diminishment of the role of language as a material component for knowledge-making - has become the norm underpinning the pedagogical discourse (Gramling and Malakaj 1, 4).

We aim to extend their arguments and the conceptual framework of LI by moving the focus beyond administrative constituencies. Instead, we seek to explore how and why the erosion of linguistic attention in English-medium instruction has also occurred within the undergraduate cohort. The existing literature contends that the causes of this decline are multifaceted and cumulative.

Structural constraints of high-stakes standardized tests in secondary education (e.g., SAT and ACT), namely time limits and multiple-choice formats, consistently reward skimming passages to arrive to the correct answer (Kayarkaya and Ünalı). This formulaic learning behavior carries over to higher education, where text becomes intrinsically more difficult and keyword spotting is punished (Collins-Dogrul and Saldaña). Previous investigations also reveal that the physical act of scrolling and the presence of hyperlinks in digital environments promote non-linear reading, which reduces reading stamina (Carr, Delgado et al.). This fragmented engagement style conditioned by both pedagogical and environmental factors buttresses outsourcing of cognitively demanding textual analysis to generative artificial intelligence (AI), leading to a self-reinforcing cycle of diminished linguistic attention that has detrimental impacts on academic performance (Konukati).

Despite the profound implications of LI for both educational quality and academic outcomes, the construct remains under-theorized and largely unmeasured by quantitative methods. To this end, we aim to propose a design and validate a psychometric instrument in the form of Likert-item attitudinal survey questions to measure the prevalence of LI among the undergraduate cohort empirically. By accentuating student ideologies of the role of language as a material component in knowledge-making, this enables us to provide institutional policy stakeholders with an evidence-based foundation that cultivates linguistic attention in the future university.

In addition, we seek to create an intervention consisting of real-world social media posts that simulates linguistic attention to everyday textual artifacts. In doing so, we aim to understand the psychological mechanisms behind LI that students uphold. Altogether, our investigation is guided by two research questions: First, what constitutes a valid, reliable metric that demonstrates adequate psychometric properties to measure LI? Second, how attentive are undergraduate students to language when analyzing a text?

The contributions of this study are twofold: aiming to advance both theoretical understanding and pedagogical policy initiatives. From a theoretical perspective, this study hopes to expand the under-theorized construct of LI by providing a psychometric instrument that rigorously assesses attitudes towards the material necessity of language for knowledge access. By serving as the empirical foundation, this study aims to provide a more robust conceptual framework of LI that guides educators and administrative policy-makers to deploy strategic reform to institutional pedagogy that elevates academic success and attenuates students' anxiety towards college-level text.

2 Theoretical Background of Linguistic Indifference

In this research proposal, we seek to operationalize LI by deriving three dimensions based on extant literature that will serve as the foundation of attitudinal

survey question design and thus latent factors.

The first dimension focuses on the separation of language form (e.g., grammar) from meaning-making. In other words, the mechanistic approach of language as a "skill set that must be mastered" and an end unto itself rather than a crucible for making meaning socializes LI (Dawson et al.). For instance, in the classroom, this may take on the form of making passive claims about an author's tone without citing specific lexico-grammatical features to justify one's assertions. It is important to note that LI is an ideological stance to language, not a methodological omission (Maxim and Ryshina-Pankova). Therefore, conceptualizing language choice not as an endeavor isolated from meaning, but as a lens that guides language form to meanings and situational and cultural contexts of use reflects a resistance to LI.

The second dimension expands on the anxiety towards and subsequent avoidance of close reading of higher education texts. As students move into undergraduate disciplines, the analysis of language choice becomes inextricably linked to their mastery of rhetorical style and "lexical richness" (Marco et al.). This encompasses lexical diversity (the variety of words used) and lexical sophistication (the proportion of advanced or technical words) (Díez-Ortega and Kyle). To this end, the aversion to textual analysis, whether it is rooted in reduced reading stamina, devaluing the text's authorship as lacking credibility, or perceiving it as a mere pedantic exercise vocalizes a reluctance of engaging with the lexical density and rhetorical nuance characteristic of higher education literature (Johansson). LI functions as a rational fix to this anxiety by "wishing away the inconvenience and complexity that languages bring," warranting a measurement of this behavior (Maxim and Ryshina-Pankova).

To placate linguistic anxiety, students may seek to outsource the cognitive labor of reading to generative AI, which we aim to evaluate as the third dimension of LI. Past studies have indicated its use functioning as a "double-edged sword." The uncritical acceptance of AI-generated content and text summarizations engenders intellectual passivity and the erosion of students' ability to independently analyze information (Hassen). In addition, replacing the need for meaningful human engagement of textual works with automated interpretations by AI threatens to cheapen the intentionality of language choices and thus authorship. Altogether, we suggest that the "productive struggle" that is attending to language is both essential to nurturing essential academic skills and an acknowledgment of the effort that was invested to impart knowledge.

Conversely, AI can function as a "socratic partner," generating various and equally rigorous arguments on a literary work that, if they run counter to initial explications, invite students to reevaluate language-borne features for clarification (Hassen). For non-native English speakers in particular, students can use AI to deconstruct challenging excerpts, ask for explanations, or simplify difficult language or concepts, which are all inherently acts of embracing language as a material necessity for knowledge (Luo). Despite the apparent paradoxical effects of AI on LI, the degree to which it fortifies or weakens linguistically indifferent attitudes is an unclear but important consideration that we seek to investigate with the proposed metric design.

3 Seven-step Design and Validity Process

In constructing a standardized metric to measure LI in the academic context, we seek to follow a systematic, seven-step design and validity process ensuring that established validity and reliability criteria are met according to the Association for Medical Education in Europe (AAME) guide (Artino et al.). Table 1 outlines the seven steps that we intend to follow. A rigorous construct definition of LI was synthesized in section 2.

Table 1: Seven-step design approach

Step 1	Construct definition
Step 2	Likert item and intervention development
Step 3	Consultation with naïve subjects, currently enrolled undergraduate students, ever enrolled in university, and content experts to ensure content validity
Step 4	Pilot test with students
Step 5	Full test
Step 6	Statistical analyses Reliability: Cronbach’s alpha (α) Validity: principal components analysis
Step 7	Standardized metric and intervention administration

Likert item and intervention development: While the lack of a standard metric remains a significant research gap in the inquiry of LI, an analysis of existing metrics will be synthesized with the consultation of content experts, namely tenured professors at Emory University, to review and determine whether some elements in the current literature can be adapted into the proposed instrument. However, all items have hitherto been generated from scratch. These items were produced to be concise and avoid double-barreled items. Sub-scales were made to measure student attitudes in relation to the dimensions of LI discussed in section 2. All items are derived from the Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree to 6 = strongly agree). All items are displayed in Table 2.

Table 2: Proposed attitudinal survey questions and their respective criteria (* = reverse-coded)

Language-as-Skill

1. As long as I understand the general idea of a text, paying attention to specific word choices is unnecessary.
2. Grammar, tone, and syntax are mostly surface-level features that do not significantly affect meaning.
3. Analyzing an author’s language is less important than identifying the main argument or conclusion.
4. I see language rules as something to master for correctness, not as tools for making meaning.
5. When instructors focus heavily on wording or phrasing, it feels like overanalyzing rather than real learning.
6. An author’s specific language choices shape how knowledge is constructed.*

Anxiety Toward and Avoidance of Close Reading

7. I often feel overwhelmed when texts require close attention to wording or rhetorical nuance.
8. I try to get through difficult academic readings as quickly as possible rather than engaging deeply with the language.
9. Analyzing how a text is written feels more stressful than worthwhile.
10. When a text uses complex or unfamiliar vocabulary, I tend to disengage rather than work through it.
11. Close reading feels like an unnecessary exercise that rarely improves my understanding.
12. Working through complex or technical language usually deepens my understanding of a text.*

AI Outsourcing

13. If an AI tool can summarize a text for me, there is little reason to read the original carefully.
 14. I usually trust AI-generated explanations without checking how the original text is worded.
 15. Using AI helps me avoid dealing with difficult language in academic texts.
 16. AI interpretations make close attention to an author’s language less necessary.
 17. I see AI primarily as a shortcut rather than a tool for engaging more deeply with language.
 18. I use AI to help me understand difficult language before returning to the original text.*
 19. AI prompts me to reexamine how language shapes meaning.*
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Consultation with naïve subjects, currently enrolled undergraduate students, ever enrolled in university, and content experts to ensure content validity: To ensure content validity, an electronic version of proposed scales will be distributed to undergraduate students, individuals who have never attended university as naïve informants, individuals who have attended in or graduated from university in the past, and questionnaire design experts to maximize clarity and item quality. After potential revisions are made, the questionnaire will be circulated among content experts who have taught or have experience with LI to confirm that the items are appropriate to measure LI in the academic context.

Pilot test: The questionnaire and intervention will be piloted among undergraduate and graduate students currently enrolled in a university in Georgia. Covariates, such as gender, age, major, minor, race, native language, English proficiency, other language proficiency, and socioeconomic status, will be controlled so as to not be confounding. After completion of the survey, Cronbach’s alpha and corrected item-total correlations will be used to measure internal consistency. Items with Cronbach’s alpha that are less than 0.30 and not essential to topic coverage discussed in Table 2 will be discarded (Ferketich). Items with Cronbach’s alpha greater than 0.70 demonstrate adequate internal consistency and will be administered in future surveys (Tavakol and Dennick). Participant information will be confidential throughout the study and consent will be obtained prior to the pilot test.

Full test: After revisions are made, survey and intervention administration will expand to include students attending Emory University. For our sample to be representative of undergraduate, we will aim to have a sample size of about 385 participants to maintain 95% confidence intervals (Althubaiti). Covariates from the pilot test will continue to be controlled and participant information will remain confidential throughout the study and during the publication process. After the full test is complete, response time will be recorded and participant responses will be recorded for statistical analysis.

Statistical analyses: Survey results will be submitted for statistical analysis to estimate reliability and construct validity using R Software for Mac 15.0. Each item will be scored individually, and those that are phrased negatively will be reverse coded. Reliability will be tested using Cronbach’s alpha again to measure internal consistency and construct validity will be tested using factor analysis. Factor analysis is defined as the reduction of large number of variables into a small set of underlying factors to account for the pattern of correlations among a set of measures (Fabrigar and Wegener). The Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin (KMO) and Bartlett’s test will be used to determine whether the sample size is adequate to perform factor analysis. Any KMO value between 0.6 and 1 will be considered optimal for this study (Field 2024). To address endogeneity, each construct will be hypothesized based on the content of the items that load on corresponding factors. Items that do not load on any factors will be discarded

since they do not contribute to the intended constructs. Principal component analysis (PCA) with Varimax rotation will be applied to determine whether item groupings in each sub-scale align with their respective constructs and to maximize interpretability while reducing cross-loading.

Standardized Metric and Intervention administration: The final version will be administered in a cross-sectional sample drawn from the aforementioned student populations that is large enough to adequately perform factor analysis. After repeating internal reliability and construct validity procedures, convergent validity will be examined by correlating scale scores with established, related measures, and divergent validity with unrelated constructs. Known-groups comparisons (e.g. majors vs non-majors) and concurrent correlations with behavioral proxies (e.g. time spent studying) will provide additional criterion evidence.

4 Hypotheses

1. **The Construct Validity Hypothesis:** a psychometric instrument composed of Likert-item survey questions will successfully operationalize LI as a multidimensional construct consisting of three distinct latent factors: the separate of language form from meaning-making, the avoidance of close reading, and the outsourcing of cognitive labor to AI.
2. **The Reliability Hypothesis:** the proposed LI scale will demonstrate adequate internal consistency with the aforementioned Cronbach's alpha score exceeding the 0.70 threshold for all dimensions, mirroring the psychometric success of related ideological measures.
3. **The Intervention Efficacy Hypothesis:** Participation in the pedagogical intervention using real-world social media posts designed to simulate linguistic attention will successfully portray how LI manifests in the responses that subjects provide.
4. **The Language-as-Skill Hypothesis:** Students who conceptualize language strictly as a skill set that must be mastered rather than a material necessity for knowledge-making will demonstrate higher levels of linguistic anxiety and lower overall academic literacy.
5. **The Mediation of Text Difficulty Hypothesis:** LI will serve as a significant mediating variable in the relationship between students' perceptions of intrinsic text difficulty and their actual academic performance. Higher perceived difficulty will lead to higher LI scores, which in turn will correlate with reduced attention to language.
6. **The AI-Outsourcing Hypothesis:** High levels of LI will significantly predict the frequency with which a student chooses to outsource cognitively demanding textual analysis to generative AI tools.

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